

Design System Reference — "Mailchimp-Inspired" Style Guide

Purpose of this document: This is a portable design-system reference extracted from Mailchimp's real, official brand identity (colors, typography, spacing, voice, motion). Paste this entire file into the context of any AI coding agent (Claude, GPT, Cursor, etc.) at the start of a new web/landing-page project, and it will have everything it needs to replicate this visual direction — color tokens, font pairing, button/card patterns, illustration style, and tone of voice — without you having to re-explain it each time.

1. Brand Personality (the "why" behind every visual choice)

Mailchimp's identity is built around one tension: **professional enough to trust with your business, playful enough to not feel corporate**. Every visual decision should serve that balance.

- **Tone words:** friendly, confident, a little cheeky, optimistic, editorial (not salesy), human.
- **Visual strategy:** loud in one place (color), quiet everywhere else (layout, grid, restraint). One bold accent color used with confidence — large color fields, high contrast — rather than gradients or multiple competing brights.
- **Anti-pattern to avoid:** generic SaaS-blue, glassmorphism, stock-photo corporate look. The brand deliberately broke from "every SaaS site looks the same."

2. Color Palette

Primary (hero) colors

Token	Name	Hex	RGB	Usage
<code>--color-brand-primary</code>	Cavendish Yellow	 #FFE01B	255, 224, 27	Hero color. CTAs, highlights, backgrounds for emphasis blocks, hover states. Used boldly and in large fields — not as a small accent.
<code>--color-ink</code>	Peppercorn	 #241C15	36, 28, 21	Primary text, dark backgrounds, button text/fills. A warm near-black (not pure <code>#000</code>) — softer than true black.

Token	Name	Hex	RGB	Usage
<code>--color-bg-cream</code>	Off-white / Cream	 <code>#EFEDE9</code>	239, 237, 233	Primary page background instead of pure white — gives warmth.
<code>--color-bg-white</code>	White	 <code>#FFFFFF</code>	255, 255, 255	Card backgrounds, contrast surfaces on top of cream.

Secondary / supporting palette (used sparingly, for variety across sections — never all at once)

Token	Hex (approx.)	Usage
<code>--color-accent-green</code>	 <code>#2D4F35</code> (muted forest green)	Section backgrounds, illustration fills
<code>--color-accent-peach</code>	 <code>#F4C9A4</code> (warm peach/tan)	Soft section backgrounds, illustration skin/warmth tones
<code>--color-accent-blue</code>	 <code>#1B3358</code> (deep navy-blue)	Contrast section, trust/data-heavy content
<code>--color-accent-red</code>	 <code>#C8442E</code> (warm brick red)	Sparingly — alerts, energetic accents, never as primary CTA

Color rules for an AI agent to follow:

- 1. Cream/white is the default canvas — yellow is a spotlight, not wallpaper. Use it on ~10–20% of a page (a hero band, one CTA block, a highlight card), not as the global background.
- 2. Pair yellow with Peppercorn text for AA-safe contrast (do not use yellow as a text color on light backgrounds).
- 3. One secondary accent color per section is enough — don't combine green + peach + blue on the same screen.
- 4. Buttons: primary CTA = Peppercorn fill with cream/white text, OR Cavendish Yellow fill with Peppercorn text. Keep it to these two patterns.

```
:root {
  --color-brand-primary: #FFE01B; /* Cavendish Yellow */
  --color-ink: #241C15;           /* Peppercorn */
  --color-bg-cream: #EFEDE9;
  --color-bg-white: #FFFFFF;
  --color-accent-green: #2D4F35;
  --color-accent-peach: #F4C9A4;
  --color-accent-blue: #1B3358;
  --color-accent-red: #C8442E;
}
```

3. Typography

Mailchimp pairs **one characterful serif display face** with **one purposefully plain sans-serif** — this is the core of the system's personality. Do not substitute both for the same family; the contrast is the point.

Display / Headline typeface — "Means" (custom, by Commercial Type)

- An elegant serif with quirky warmth — rounded corners, editorial tone, light-weight by default.
- **Not freely licensed** — for your own projects, use an accessible substitute with the same character: a **light-weight, rounded-corner serif** such as:
 - `"Fraunces"` (Google Fonts) — closest free equivalent (variable, has the rounded/soft serif quality)
 - or `"Lora"` / `"Noto Serif"` light weight as a safer fallback
- Used at **light font-weight**, large sizes, for H1/H2/hero headlines only. Generous letter-spacing, never used for long body copy.

Body / UI typeface — "Graphik"

- Purposefully plain sans-serif. Prioritizes legibility, balances the expressiveness of the display face. Used for body copy, navigation, buttons, captions, data.
- **Free equivalents:** `"Inter"`, `"Söhne"`-style, or `"Work Sans"` — clean, neutral, geometric-humanist sans.

```
:root {
  --font-display: "Fraunces", Georgia, serif;      /* headline / hero */
  --font-body: "Inter", "Helvetica Neue", Arial, sans-serif; /* body / UI */
}
```

Type scale (reference — adjust per project)

Role	Font	Weight	Size (desktop)	Notes
Hero H1	Display	Light (300)	56-80px	Editorial, can wrap to 2-3 lines
H2	Display	Light/Regular	36-44px	
H3	Display or Body	Regular/Medium	24-28px	
Body	Body	Regular (400)	16-18px	Max paragraph width ~635px for readability
Caption / label	Body	Medium (500)	13-14px	
Button text	Body	Medium/Semibold	15-16px	

Rule: Headlines are conversational and longer than typical SaaS copy ("Email & SMS marketing, minus the learning curve") — not just a noun phrase. Body copy stays plain and functional.

4. Layout, Spacing & Shape

- **Background:** warm cream ( #EFEDE9), not stark white — gives the whole site a paper-like, friendly warmth.
- **Grid:** generous whitespace, clear vertical rhythm. Sections are large, full-bleed color blocks alternating with cream — this is how the page gets visual variety without extra colors competing on screen at once.
- **Corner radius:** soft but not bubbly — buttons and cards use moderate rounding (8-16px), not full pill shapes everywhere, not sharp corners either. Logo/illustration elements can use fully rounded or organic blob shapes for warmth.

- **Cards:** white surface on cream background, soft shadow or simple border, generous internal padding (24-40px).
 - **Section rhythm:** alternate background color per section (cream → dark Peppercorn → cream → yellow highlight → cream) to create pacing as the user scrolls, rather than one flat background the whole way down.
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5. Components

Buttons (primary CTA):

- Peppercorn ( #241C15) fill, cream/white text, rounded corners (~8-12px), medium-weight label, generous horizontal padding.
- Secondary CTA: outlined or Cavendish Yellow fill with Peppercorn text.
- Hover: subtle scale or color-shift (yellow ↔ darker yellow, or fill ↔ outline) — kept simple, not flashy.

Navigation:

- Clean horizontal nav on cream/white background, Peppercorn text, no heavy borders — relies on whitespace for separation.
- Dropdown mega-menus use simple typographic lists (no icons-heavy clutter), occasional small icon next to utility links (Help, Case Studies).

Cards / feature blocks:

- White card on cream background OR colored illustration block + short headline + one-line description + text link below (not always a button — text links with arrows are common for secondary actions).

Forms:

- Simple, rounded input fields, plenty of label spacing, friendly micro-copy ("Hi, let's get started" tone rather than "Submit Form").

Ratings / social proof:

- Star ratings + customer logos in a simple horizontal row, muted/grayscale logos so they don't compete with brand color.
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6. Imagery & Illustration Style

- **Hand-drawn, off-kilter, slightly imperfect illustrations** — personal expression over photorealism. Not stock photography as the primary visual language.
 - Illustrations use the brand's secondary accent palette (peach, green, blue, red) against cream/white, rather than full-color realistic renders.
 - A recurring mascot/character device (Mailchimp uses "Freddie," a winking chimp) — if your brand has a mascot or icon character, this is the model: simple, single-color/silhouette-friendly, appears consistently paired with the wordmark.
 - Photography (when used): warm, candid, real-people-in-real-small-business-settings — not overly polished stock photography.
 - Icons: simple line or solid single-color icons, not skeuomorphic or heavily detailed.
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7. Motion & Effects

- **Restrained, not flashy.** Motion is used to add warmth (a wink, a subtle illustration loop) rather than to impress.
 - Scroll-based reveals: simple fade/slide-up on section entry, nothing aggressive.
 - Hover states: small, fast (150–250ms), simple — color shift, slight scale (1.02–1.05x), or underline animation on links.
 - Avoid: parallax-heavy effects, 3D tilts, glassmorphism blur, heavy gradients, neon glows. The brand's energy comes from color and copy, not motion complexity.
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8. Voice & Microcopy

- **Active voice, plain verbs, sentence case.** "Drive revenue with intuitive marketing analytics" — not "Revenue-Driving Solutions Powered By AI."
 - Headlines can be longer and conversational, often split into a confident statement + a softening, witty second clause (e.g., "X, minus the learning curve").
 - Buttons say exactly what happens: "Start Free Trial," "See Pricing," "Learn More" — never vague ("Submit," "Click Here").
 - Empty/error states are explained plainly, in the product's voice, never apologetic or robotic.
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9. Quick-Reference Token Block (paste directly into a project)

json

```
{
  "brand_personality": "professional but playful, confident, editorial, human,
  "colors": {
    "primary": "#FFE01B",
    "ink": "#241C15",
    "background_cream": "#EFEDE9",
    "background_white": "#FFFFFF",
    "accent_green": "#2D4F35",
    "accent_peach": "#F4C9A4",
    "accent_blue": "#1B3358",
    "accent_red": "#C8442E"
  },
  "typography": {
    "display_font": "Fraunces (light weight) – rounded, warm serif for headline
    "body_font": "Inter – plain, legible sans-serif for everything else",
    "rule": "always pair one expressive serif display face with one plain sans-
  },
  "shape": {
    "corner_radius": "8-16px on cards/buttons, soft not sharp, not full pill by
    "background_default": "warm cream, not pure white"
  },
  "layout": {
    "rhythm": "alternate full-bleed section backgrounds (cream / dark / cream /
    "whitespace": "generous; max body paragraph width ~635px"
  },
  "components": {
    "primary_button": "Peppercorn fill, cream text, 8-12px radius",
    "secondary_button": "Cavendish Yellow fill, Peppercorn text – OR outline st
    "links": "text links with arrow for secondary actions, not always buttons"
  },
  "imagery": "hand-drawn, slightly imperfect illustration over stock photograph
  "motion": "restrained – fade/slide-up on scroll, fast subtle hover states, no
  "voice": "active voice, plain verbs, sentence case, specific over clever, lon
}
```

How to use this document

1. Save this file in your project repo (e.g. `/design/design-system.md`).

2. When starting a new project with an AI coding agent, attach or paste this file along with your brief: *"Use this design system as the visual foundation, adapted to [your subject/brand]."*
 3. Treat Section 9's JSON block as the literal token source — an agent can lift hex codes and font names straight from there.
 4. **Important:** this is a *style direction*, not a copy of Mailchimp's trademarked logo, mascot, or wordmark. Don't reuse "Freddie," the Mailchimp name, or their exact logo — the *system* (color logic, type pairing, layout rhythm, voice) is what's portable; the specific brand assets are not.
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Compiled from Mailchimp's official brand guidelines (mailchimp.com/about/brand-assets), Commercial Type's documentation of the "Means" typeface, and current site structure analysis (June 2026).